However, monthly per capita rural consumption rose by **18** per cent in real terms in 2011-12 over 2009-10, while monthly per capita urban consumption rose by only **13.3** per cent. Thus, the rate of increase in the MPCE of rural areas is higher than that of urban areas, indicating a bridging of the rural-urban gap. Out of the MPCE, the share of food as per 66th round NSS data (2009-10) is Rs. 600 (57 per cent) and Rs. 881 (44 per cent) for rural and urban India, respectively, showing a higher share for food in rural compared to urban India [as per the latest *Economic Survey 2012-13*].

EMPLOYMENT

For growth to be inclusive, it must create adequate livelihood opportunities and add to decent employment commensurate with the expectations of a growing labour force. The Eleventh Five Year Plan (2007-12) aimed at generation of 58 million work opportunities. The NSSO quinquennial survey has reported an increase in work opportunities to the tune of 18 million under the current daily status (CDS) between 2004-05 and 2009-10. However, the overall labour force expanded by only 11.7 million. This was considerably lower than in comparable periods earlier, and can be attributed to the much larger retention of youth in education and also because of lower labour force participation among working-age women. As a result, unemployment in absolute terms came down by 6.3 million. The lower growth in the labour force is not expected to continue as educated youth are expected to join the labour force in increasing numbers during the Twelfth Plan and in the years beyond.

This means that the pace of job/ livelihood creation must be greatly accelerated. The Twelfth Plan Approach Paper therefore lays greater stress on skill building which can be viewed as an instrument for improving the effectiveness and contribution of labour to overall production. This will push the production possibility frontier outward and take the economy on to a higher growth trajectory and can also be viewed as a means of empowerment.

Unemployment